

WORKSHOP REPORT

Identifying Learning Disabilities and Basic Intervention Approaches

Resource Person: Ms. Naseeha Nasar, Educational Psychologist

Quick Brief Summary

Ms. Naseeha Nazar explained that Specific Learning Disabilities (SLD) are conditions related to brain function, and can be managed through accurate differential diagnosis and multi-sensory interventions. Identifying such disabilities by the age of eight can help boost a child's self-confidence and foster better overall development.

Introduction

This workshop focused on Learning Disability (LD), a significant topic within Educational Psychology. The session was led by educational psychologist Ms. Naseeha Nazar. She opened by highlighting how essential this subject is for those working in the academic field, and assured participants that the workshop would help them identify learning disabilities and apply fundamental intervention strategies.

Main Topic: Identifying and Intervening in Specific Learning Disability (SLD)

A learning disability is not merely an inability to learn, but rather an obstacle in understanding, retrieving, and practically applying information. The speaker emphasized that not all academic backwardness is a learning disability, and that it can only be confirmed through accurate differential diagnosis.

Key Concepts

Causes and Nature of Learning Disability

A learning disability is a neurological condition, caused by deficiencies in the coordination of functions between various parts of the brain — the parieto-temporal lobe, Broca's area, and the occipito-temporal lobe. For example, children with dyslexia experience difficulty blending letters and sounds. Such children may find it more difficult to learn 'opaque' languages like English compared to 'transparent' languages like Malayalam.

Types of Learning Disabilities

The speaker explained three main types:

- Dyslexia — reading disability
- Dysgraphia — writing disability, with sub-types including lexical, motor, and spatial
- Dyscalculia — mathematical disability, with verbal, lexical, and operational forms explained through examples

She reminded participants that it is essential to identify and encourage a child's strengths alongside addressing their weaknesses.

Diagnosis and Intervention

Early identification of learning disabilities within the age of eight is crucial for a child's future. In India, diagnosis is conducted using tools such as the NIMHANS SLD Battery. Children identified with SLD can be brought into the mainstream through multi-sensory teaching methods and assistive technologies. She also clarified that acquired learning disability, caused by accidents, is distinct from neurological SLD.

Key Insights

1. Differential Diagnosis — SLD must be confirmed by ruling out issues with hearing, vision, and IQ.
2. Early Intervention — Early identification helps avoid inferiority complexes in children and prevents behavioural problems.
3. Multi-sensory Approach — Making learning activity-oriented helps strengthen neural connections.
4. Assistive Technology — Using dyslexia-friendly websites and tools makes the learning process easier.

Identifying Learning Disability (SLD)

Not all academic backwardness is a learning disability. SLD refers to specific learning disabilities found in children with an IQ in the 90–110 range. It should only be confirmed through differential diagnosis, excluding vision, hearing, and intellectual limitations.

Neurological Basis and Symptoms

Dyslexia, dysgraphia, and dyscalculia arise from functional differences in the brain. Abnormalities in the functioning of Broca's area, the parieto-temporal lobe, and the occipito-temporal lobe affect reading and writing. Early identification helps preserve a child's self-confidence.

Intervention Methods

Children's skills can be improved using multi-sensory teaching methods. Grip training is essential to improve writing, and activity-oriented learning is vital for mathematics. If there is no change after six months of continuous training, assistive technologies should be introduced.

Conclusion

The speaker reminded participants that a learning disability is not the end of a child's life, and that with the right support and guidance, such children can reach great heights. Citing examples of well-known individuals, including Sachin Tendulkar, she called on educators and parents to focus on children's talents rather than only their difficulties. The session concluded with a question-and-answer segment followed by a vote of thanks.